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From 0 to 1 Million Users in 6 Months: How I Built My Viral App (Complete Playbook)

submitted to

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Abstract

This thesis documents how I co-founded and scaled *Glam Up*, an AI beauty app, to over one million users (and \$150K MRR) between May and November 2024 — without paid ads, funding, or a pre-existing audience. Built on live experimentation and behavioral psychology, this paper breaks down how my co-founder and I engineered virality through required referrals, TikTok-optimized content loops, and emotionally timed monetization. Drawing on user data from App Store Developer Console, PostHog and Superwall, I analyze what drove conversions, what failed, and how content became our distribution engine. I also reflect on the mindset behind building fast-moving consumer apps — staying scrappy, being aware, and knowing when it's time to walk away. This isn't a universal playbook, but a tactical case study of what actually worked, what didn't, and how delusional faith, smart systems, and emotional insight helped scale one of the fastest-growing Gen Z apps of 2024. If you're building in the AI consumer space, I hope this gives you something useful to learn from.

Acknowledgements

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1. Introduction

Glam Up is an AI beauty consultant app that helps users discover their color analysis, ideal makeup products, facial features, and personalized beauty routines through facial scanning. It launched in May 2024 and reached over one million users within six months.

As the co-founder of Glam Up, I was intimately involved in everything it took to grow the app from a scrappy idea to one of the fastest-growing AI beauty apps of the year. I wasn't a seasoned entrepreneur with years of experience in venture-backed startups, nor did I have a massive marketing budget to throw at paid ads. What I did have, however, was spontaneity, delusional faith, and the grit to figure things out as I went.

This thesis analyzes the strategies we used to scale Glam Up — referral loops, TikTok virality, paywall psychology, and creator content — and how each impacted user growth and monetization. While B2C consumer apps are often seen as riskier and harder to monetize, Glam Up challenged that assumption. B2B startups consistently receive a larger share of VC funding, with reports showing that over 70% of early-stage capital in recent years has flowed toward

enterprise-focused ventures (Pitchbook, 2023). As a result, not many people actually know how to grow a B2C app from scratch, let alone make it go viral without paid ads or celebrity backing.

The idea for Glam Up didn't come from a five-year roadmap or a pitch deck—it came from a chaotic 10-minute phone call. I had been living in San Francisco for four months when I met my co-founder [REDACTED]. One night in late March 2024 when I moved back to school, he called me out of the blue and asked if I wanted to build an app together. I said yes.

Before diving in more, it's helpful to understand who we are and what Glam Up actually does. I studied psychology and economics at [REDACTED], hosted a TikTok podcast that went viral in 10 days when I was solo-traveling in Europe, and had interned at TikTok before and studied marketing extensively. My co-founder, [REDACTED] was a second-time founder. He was in Y-Combinator when he was 18, building a B2B logistics company that later got acquired. He is a deeply first-principled thinker and came up with many of the ideas that made Glam Up work, especially around product features and virality loops.

By the end of the call, we landed on an AI beauty app for girls. Glam Up is an AI beauty consultant. You can scan your face on the app, and Glam Up will provide different analyzes: facial analysis, color analysis, and glow up guide (you get to see how you'd look in different makeup styles). Glam Up also provides personalized product recommendations and makeup routines based on your facial features and skin conditions.

At that time, neither of us (me and [REDACTED] had built a consumer AI app before, but we knew beauty was a massive industry worth over \$500 billion globally. The beauty industry was also growing fast with Gen Z fueling a wave of hyper-personalized trends (McKinsey & Company). AI felt like the perfect tool to make beauty more accessible and less overwhelming. While there were no direct competitors doing exactly what we were doing (an AI-powered glow

up and scan experience for girls), we were loosely inspired by a looksmaxxing glow up app for guys that had recently gone viral (UMaxx). Most people at the time were still relying on scattered methods to figure out their makeup: TikTok trends, asking friends, doing online quizzes, or wandering through Sephora overwhelmed. There was no clear way to figure out “what actually works for my face,” and Glam Up aimed to replace that confusion with something visual, instant, and personalized. That night, we sketched out the first version of what would become Glam Up — half-joking, half-serious, and fully convinced we’d figure it out.

The challenge wasn’t just building the app — it was figuring out how to make it go viral. We had no funding, no marketing team, and no existing audience. What we did have was a sharp intuition for internet culture. My experience in marketing was also shaped by my obsession with psychology, my TikTok podcast that blew up in 10 days, and my previous internship at TikTok (ByteDance). I had seen virality from every angle: as a creator, as an insider, and as someone obsessed with what makes people click, share, and care.

Instead of relying on expensive paid ads, we leaned into organic growth through influencer collaborations and UGC (user-generated content) from faceless accounts—pages that repost aesthetic beauty content without showing a personal identity. These types of accounts gave us scalable distribution without relying on traditional influencer deals. Every feature we built, every piece of content we created, was designed with one goal: maximize virality, even if we didn’t fully know what would work until we tested it.

In this thesis, I’ll break down the specific marketing strategies and growth experiments that helped Glam Up go viral. I’ll use real behavioral data from App Store Developer Console, PostHog, our product analytics tool, and Superwall, our paywall optimization platform, to analyze what actually drove downloads and conversions. My approach is part reflection and part

case study — structured around hypotheses we formed about virality, paywall behavior, and social incentives, and how those hypotheses played out in the real world.

By the end of this thesis, my goal is to provide a playbook for anyone looking to launch their own AI consumer app — one that scales to 1M users within 6 months. This is the story of how I took Glam Up from an idea to one of the fastest-growing AI beauty apps, and the lessons I learned along the way. [REDACTED]

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2. Data Sources and Metrics

This thesis draws on internal data collected from the following tools:

- PostHog – used for product analytics, including page views, session tracking, funnel progression, and referral triggers.
- Superwall – used to track paywall impressions, conversion rates, subscription tier breakdowns, and recurring revenue.
- TikTok Analytics – used to analyze content performance, including view counts, engagement rate, and share velocity across TikTok creators and formats.
- In-app event logs – used to monitor user behavior including scan selections, selfie uploads, and upgrade purchases.
- Apple App Store Developer Console – used to access verified subscription revenue and download data, broken down by month and device (iOS-only). This was the primary source for all revenue and conversion metrics presented in Section 6.4.

The key metrics referenced throughout this paper include:

- Unique users – first-time app opens.

- Paywall open rate – percentage of users who reached the paywall after completing onboarding and scan flow.
- Subscription conversion rate – percentage of users who subscribed after seeing the paywall.
- Weekly active users (WAU) – used for engagement snapshots.
- Referral shares triggered – counts each time a user shared their referral code.
- Monthly recurring revenue (MRR) – broken down into new vs. renewing subscription revenue.

These metrics form the foundation for the quantitative analysis presented throughout the paper.

3. Literature Review

The virality and monetization of Glam Up sit at the intersection of behavioral psychology, marketing strategy, and user-centered product design. While traditional tech literature often overlooks consumer AI apps, newer studies help explain how and why apps like Glam Up succeed. This section draws from research in four key areas: unconventional startup pathways, influencer marketing effectiveness, pricing in freemium apps, and intellectual property as a growth and defense tool.

Lean startup methodology has long dominated startup education (Ries, 2011). The core idea is simple: build fast, test constantly, and iterate based on real-world feedback. Glam Up followed this model almost by accident. We didn't start with a polished vision or a five-year roadmap — we started with a 10-minute phone call and a rough idea. From there, everything was tested live: onboarding flows, pricing, referral systems, and TikTok content. Bingham and Eisenhardt (2011) find that in high-velocity environments, flexible experimentation outperforms

structured planning. Their work supports the idea that spontaneous, iterative growth can outperform well-funded but rigid startups. Moreover, Eisenmann et al. (2012) argue that early-stage consumer startups are better served by hypotheses and rapid testing than by long-term financial projections, especially in Gen Z markets where tastes shift quickly. The spontaneous build-then-iterate model isn't a liability; it's an advantage when targeting cultural trends and platforms like TikTok. Glam Up's ability to move fast, experiment often, and double down on what worked wasn't just a strategy – it was a necessity. In the fast-moving world of consumer AI and TikTok-driven trends, that flexibility became our biggest advantage.

While Glam Up was built through quick testing and gut instinct, most consumer apps grow by leaning on social trust, especially social media marketing. Influencer marketing effectiveness has been studied extensively in the context of consumer behavior. Lou and Yuan (2019) demonstrate that influencer trustworthiness and similarity to the viewer increase brand credibility and purchase intent. While influencer marketing didn't work directly for Glam Up, our shift from macro-influencers to relatable UGC creators and faceless beauty accounts was successful (discussed in Section 7). De Veirman et al. (2017) found that influencer follower count is inversely related to trust when controlling for engagement. In other words, micro-influencers, especially those who appear non-commercial, can drive higher conversion because users perceive their recommendations as genuine. This explains why Glam Up's aesthetic, faceless content generated more shares and conversions than traditional influencer campaigns. Further, Labrecque (2014) highlights the role of parasocial interaction — the one-sided psychological relationships people form with media figures. These interactions increase emotional attachment and explain why emotionally framed TikToks convert better than generic explainer content.

Freemium models have been dissected in dozens of pricing studies, especially in mobile gaming and wellness apps. Yang et al. (2020) provide empirical support that conversion rates increase when apps delay monetization until users experience functional value. This supports Glam Up’s decision to delay the paywall until after the facial scanning animation, leveraging anticipation and commitment bias to increase conversions (discussed in Section 6). Tversky and Kahneman (1991) developed the loss aversion principle: people are more motivated to avoid losing something than to gain something of equal value. Glam Up applied this through its post-paywall discount tactic—users were first offered full price, rejected it, and then faced a 50% discount (a framed “loss” if ignored). Ariely (2008) adds that price anchoring—seeing a high price first—makes subsequent prices feel more reasonable. Seufert (2022) also emphasizes the importance of multi-step monetization flows in consumer apps, where users are primed over several interactions instead of being asked to pay upfront. This strategy is known to improve both revenue and perceived value. Combining behavioral economics with timing and emotional buildup allowed Glam Up to maintain viral growth without sacrificing monetization—a rare balance in freemium models.

In the consumer space, IP isn’t just about legal protection—it’s about building defensible visibility. Gans and Stern (2019) argue that for digital startups, the strongest protection comes not from patents but from speed, branding, and network effects. This aligns with Glam Up’s strategy of dominating TikTok and Instagram feeds with visually recognizable, emotionally resonant scan results. While copyright and trademarks offer some protection (WIPO, 2021), the literature shows that perceived ownership of a user experience is often more powerful. Varian (1998) explains that in the digital age, information goods like apps derive their value from attention and usage, not scarcity. This means the most viral apps win not by locking others out,

but by staying top-of-mind and culturally embedded. Apps like Poparazzi, Clubhouse, and BeReal all saw copycats—yet the original brands maintained dominance due to faster iteration and stronger community identification. Glam Up followed the same trajectory, differentiating itself with a content engine and aesthetic that were difficult to replicate at scale. We didn't rely on patents or trademarks to protect Glam Up. Instead, we were driven by the unique visual language we created, from scan animations to Figma-branded results. That content signature made Glam Up recognizable and hard to replicate, even as competitors mimicked our functionality.

4. How To Read This Paper

This paper isn't meant to be polished theory or a guru-style playbook. It's just what actually worked, what didn't, and what I'd do differently if I were starting over. A lot of this is based on lived experience, data I pulled from tools like App Store Developer Console, PostHog and Superwall, and gut instinct refined by trial and error. Sometimes it's tactical. Sometimes it's messy. But all of it is honest.

If you're curious about the whole journey, read it cover to cover. If you're looking for something specific, jump to the section that speaks to what you're working on right now. Section 1 introduces the story behind Glam Up — what it does, how we started, and why we built it. Section 2 explains the data sources and metrics used throughout the paper. Section 3 is a literature review that connects our strategies to existing research on startups, virality, pricing, and influencer marketing. Section 4 explains how to read this paper. Section 5 dives into how we designed a viral referral loop and used TikTok to amplify it. Section 6 breaks down our monetization system — weekly pricing, emotional paywalls, and conversion data. Section 7

covers our marketing strategy, from early flops to the UGC playbook that helped us go viral. Section 8 reflects on why we didn't scale further, even when we could have. Section 9 shares the tactical playbook and mindset we now use to build all our apps. Section 10 is a personal reflection on what Glam Up meant to me. Section 11 outlines the limitations of this paper. And Section 12 wraps everything up with a final conclusion.

5. Incentivizing Referrals

In AI consumer apps, the default growth playbook is often built around paid ads and influencer deals. Brands pour money into Instagram shoutouts, TikTok collabs, and app install campaigns to get initial traction — but it rarely lasts. According to a 2023 report by Business of Apps, the average cost per install in the beauty app category exceeds \$3, and customer acquisition costs (CAC) tend to climb as competition intensifies. For a bootstrapped startup like ours, that kind of spend wasn't just risky—it was impossible.

So we asked ourselves: what if virality wasn't a bonus, but a requirement?

Our core hypothesis was simple: if users were encouraged to share the app in order to unlock features—or offered a clear tradeoff between paying or referring—we could transform user necessity into a viral loop. Instead of relying on passive word-of-mouth, we built a system where every new user could unlock their first scan by either subscribing or referring three friends. In other words, growth wouldn't be a bonus, but a part of the product's functionality.

At the time, we didn't know how powerful TikTok would become in amplifying this loop. It started as a secondary channel — we weren't banking on virality there, but we knew from my background in content and trends that it was worth experimenting with. What followed was a

series of unexpected but measurable boosts from TikTok that supercharged the referral system far beyond what we initially modeled.

This section explores the design of that referral-based growth system — what we hypothesized, how we tested it, and the unexpected role TikTok played in accelerating user acquisition, paywall conversions, and overall viral momentum.

5.1 How We Engineered Virality: Referral Loops + TikTok

When we first launched Glam Up, we knew we couldn't rely on ads. We didn't have the budget, and even if we did, the economics wouldn't have worked. So instead of spending money to acquire users, we made growth part of the product experience itself. Users had two options: either pay for a weekly subscription or refer three friends to unlock their first scan. Unlike most apps that treat referrals as optional or hidden behind settings menus, we made them central to the product. You couldn't proceed without choosing — either you pay, or you help us grow.

Let's look at what actually happened:

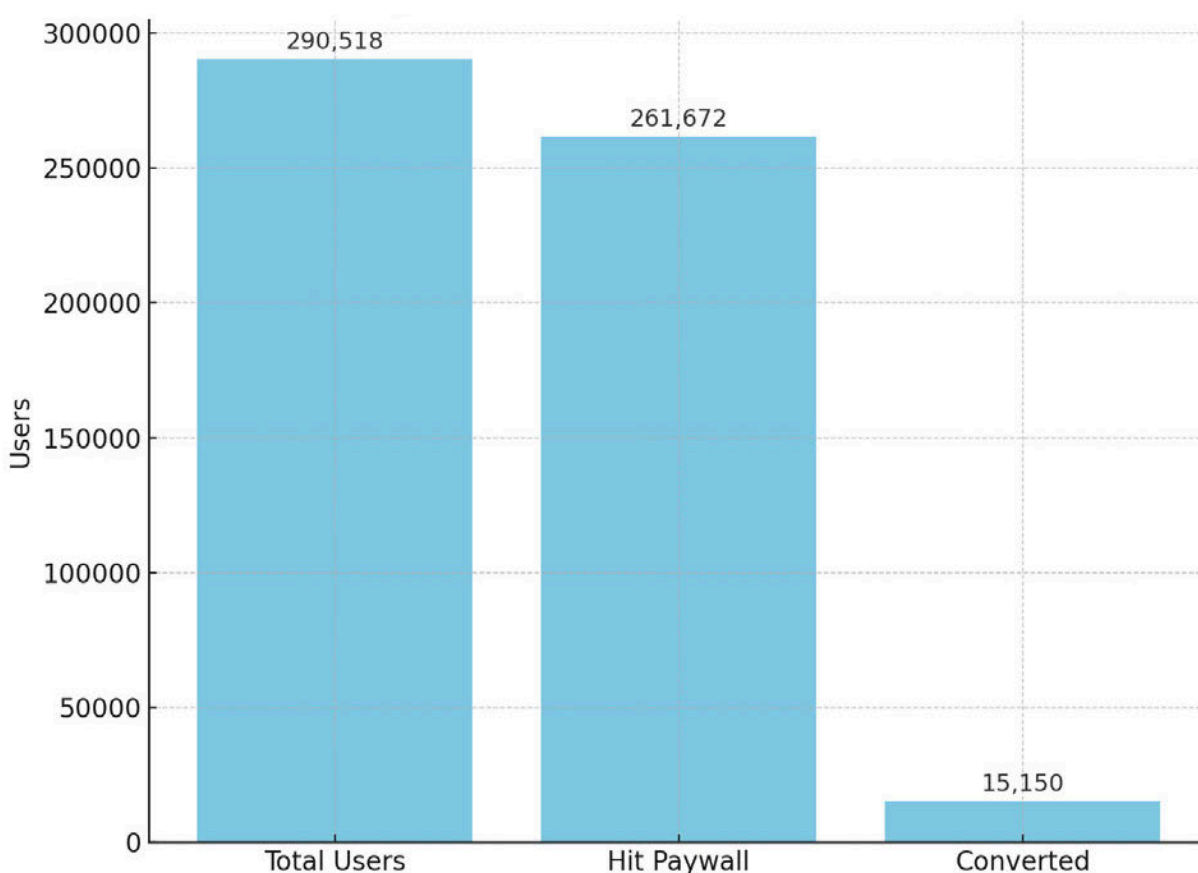
- In October 2024 alone, Glam Up gained 290,518 new users, defined here as users who opened the app and began engaging with its onboarding experience.
- 90% of those users reached the paywall, meaning they selected a scan, uploaded a photo, and stayed through the lead-up sequence. That's 261,672 users hitting the paywall.
- Out of those, 15,150 converted into paying subscribers, giving us a conversion rate of 5.8%.

This 5.8% conversion rate reflects only the users who reached the paywall — not total app downloads — and it's actually a strong result by consumer app standards. Most freemium mobile apps convert just 1–4% of users into subscribers (Clevertap, 2022), while top-performing apps in the beauty and scanning category — like Lensa AI, Facetune, and Remini — typically

see 4–7% conversion rates during periods of peak performance. Compared to those benchmarks, Glam Up’s October performance was well within a healthy range.

Despite relying purely on organic growth, Glam Up generated \$77,955 in new revenue that month alone. This wasn’t driven by ad spend or influencer hype — it was driven by a deeply optimized funnel and emotionally-timed conversion moments. The volume of users reaching the paywall, combined with strong intent and minimal friction, allowed us to monetize at a level most early-stage consumer apps struggle to reach.

Figure 1. Paywall Funnel Breakdown - October 2024

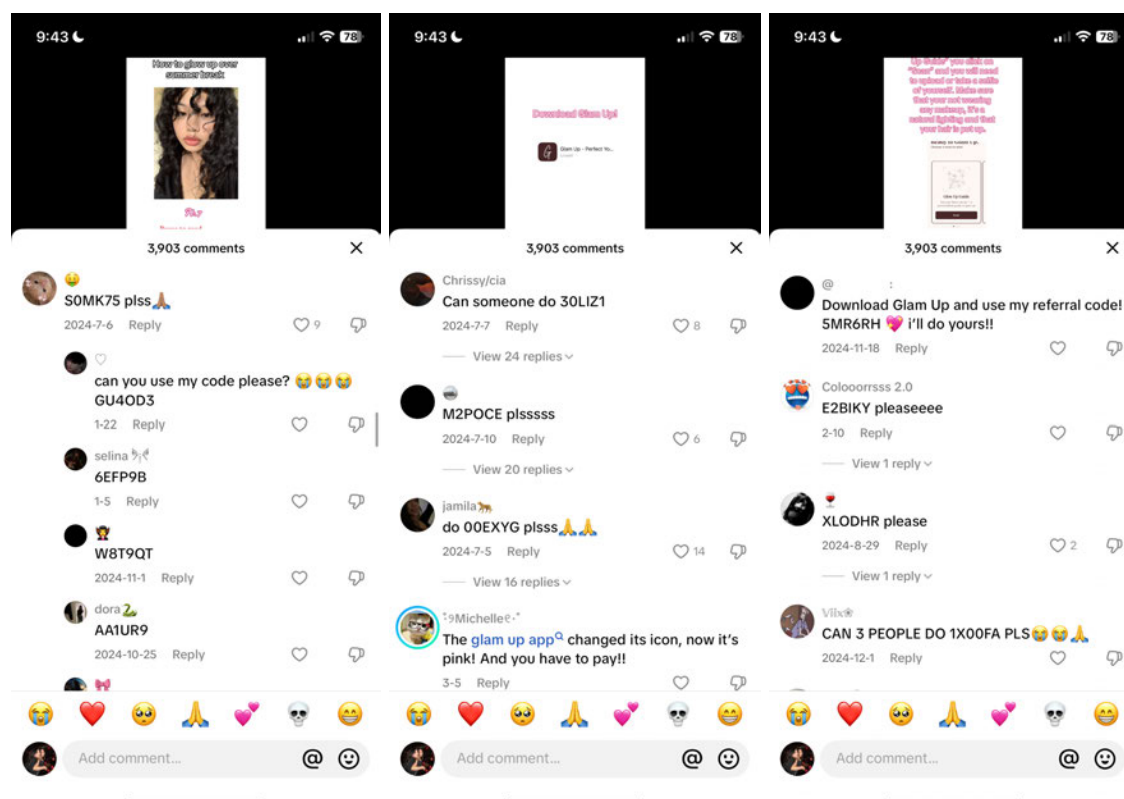


Referral codes were triggered over 1.2 million times throughout the year. While this figure likely includes retries, duplicates, or referral shares that didn’t lead to new users, it still

reflects the sheer viral momentum of the system. Referrals became the dominant acquisition channel.

And TikTok made it go exponential. Every time one of our videos went viral, the comments would flood with users dropping their referral codes — hoping others would use theirs to unlock the app. This created a feedback loop: the more people commented, the more engagement the video got, which pushed it further into the algorithm, leading to even more views and installs. We didn't need to ask users to promote us. They did it themselves, because we gave them a reason to. Screenshots of our viral posts show thousands of comments, each one a user turning into a micro-distributor.

Figure 2. TikTok Comment Surge from Referral Loop



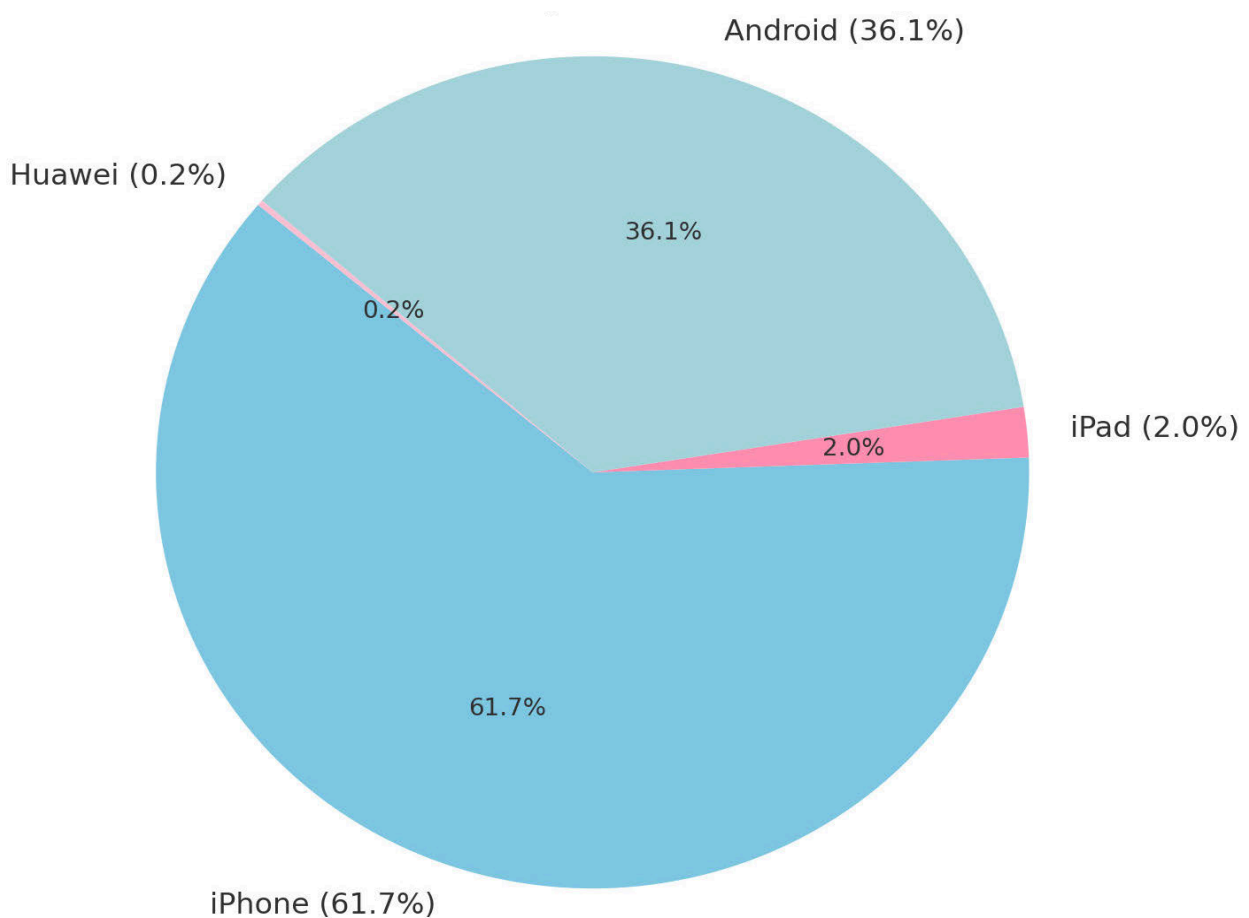
5.2 Who Was Sharing Glam Up?

While the referral system was the engine, it mattered who was doing the sharing. To better understand the viral mechanics, we broke down referral-based installs by device type — and the numbers told us a lot about our user base.

Out of all traceable referral installs, the breakdown was:

- 247,083 installs (61.7%) came from iPhones
- 144,807 installs (36.1%) from Android devices
- 7,817 installs (2.0%) from iPads
- 886 installs (<0.3%) from Huawei devices

Figure 3. Referral-Based Installs by Platforms



This strong iOS skew wasn't surprising. Most of the users who engaged with our TikTok content and shared referral codes were on iPhones. That aligns with broader trends: iPhone users dominate Gen Z beauty and lifestyle spaces and are more inclined to engage with social features. These weren't just casual downloaders; they became promoters. Our viral TikToks often featured thousands of comments with users dropping their referral codes, hoping others would use theirs to unlock the app.

We also observed a clear behavioral difference between platforms. iPhone users were far more likely to refer to friends immediately. In contrast, Android users tended to drop off more often after hitting the paywall. While we didn't conduct a full Android analysis, our internal observations indicated that the conversion rate for iOS was typically three to four times higher than for Android users. This disparity is consistent with industry-wide findings. According to data compiled by *Exploding Topics* (2024), iPhone users earn on average 43.7% more than Android users, suggesting greater disposable income and a higher propensity for in-app purchases. Additionally, iOS users log an average of 4 hours and 54 minutes of screen time per day—compared to just 3 hours and 42 minutes for Android users—making them more likely to engage with in-app content and social sharing features (Exploding Topics, 2024). These statistics are based on U.S. user data, but the trend likely holds, or is even more pronounced, at a global level, where Android fragmentation and lower average income in emerging markets contribute to weaker monetization performance and lower referral activity.

The TikTok platform itself also leans heavily toward iOS users. According to *The Social Shepherd* (2024), TikTok's daily active user base on iOS is 30.8 million, which is more than double that of Android at 15.4 million. This reinforces what we saw on the ground: our most

engaged and valuable users were part of the iOS ecosystem, both in terms of device and social behavior.

These insights guided several product decisions. We experimented with paywall UI tweaks and notification strategies tailored to each platform. But even early on, the core insight was clear: our growth strategy wasn't just about building a viral loop — it was about designing one that resonated with the culture and behavior of the people most likely to use, share, and pay for the product.

Over the past decade, consumer apps have generally followed one of two viral growth paths: (1) social-driven growth, typically powered by platforms like TikTok or Instagram, or (2) invite-based loops that rely on exclusivity and referrals. Few apps have successfully combined both in a way that compounds.

Apps like BeReal and Poparazzi scaled rapidly by leaning into TikTok trends and cultural relevance, but they never required referrals or sharing to unlock value (Shepard, 2022). On the other hand, Clubhouse and Robinhood grew by using invite-only models to build hype and social proof, especially in their early stages (Molla, 2021). However, they didn't capitalize on algorithmic amplification.

Glam Up approached growth differently: we treated TikTok and referrals as a unified system. TikTok was the awareness engine, and referrals converted that attention into user acquisition. When TikTok content went viral, it didn't just drive installs—it directly accelerated referrals, creating a flywheel of visibility and action.

This connection became especially clear between October 19–23, when our trained UGC creators posted a wave of optimized videos showcasing scan features. These videos triggered a sharp rise in referral-driven signups, from 38% to 52%, in just four days. Unlike the July spike,

which was triggered by an unpaid user video, this was fully engineered. The outcome proved that viral growth could be designed through repeatable tactics—not just luck.

TikTok's algorithm further amplified this effect. The For You Page prioritizes content with high share and comment engagement—a dynamic confirmed by leaked internal documents, which revealed that TikTok ranks videos based heavily on user interactions such as likes, comments, and watch time (Zhong & Frenkel, 2021). Since many users commented their referral codes in the comments, TikTok interpreted that behavior as high-value interaction—boosting those videos even more. This created a feedback loop: more comments → more reach → more referrals.

Ultimately, TikTok was not just a traffic source—it was the fuel that powered our referral engine. Without it, the loop wouldn't have scaled. But without the loop, the awareness wouldn't have converted. By tightly integrating top-of-funnel content with built-in virality mechanics, Glam Up turned organic social media into a self-sustaining growth system.

5.3 What This Taught Us About Viral Growth

Looking back, what made Glam Up grow wasn't one tactic. It was how everything clicked together. The referral system gave people a reason to share. The scan experience gave them something to talk about. And TikTok gave it all a stage.

What surprised us most was how little of it felt like traditional growth marketing. There were no ad budgets. No massive influencer campaigns. Just a feedback loop that turned users into promoters and curiosity into motion. We didn't force virality. We just structured the product so that users had something they wanted to spread, and a reason to do it.

We also realized that virality doesn't have to come from pure novelty. It can come from necessity. People didn't share Glam Up just because it was cool. They shared it because they had

to — to unlock the scan, to see their results, to satisfy their curiosity. It wasn't "growth hacking." It was a growth design.

That insight shaped everything that came next. It made us rethink how to monetize (Section 2), how to build product features, and even how to work with creators. We didn't just want attention. We wanted momentum. And that meant designing every part of the user journey — from first download to first referral — with psychology, timing, and social behavior in mind.

6. Monetization

When we thought about how to monetize Glam Up, we weren't trying to build a perfect pricing model from day one. We just wanted something simple that fit the way users actually behaved. A lot of AI consumer apps either monetize too early or push expensive plans without emotional timing. For Glam Up, we chose to design monetization around curiosity, impulse, and lightweight choices. This section breaks down what that looked like: our pricing decisions, the psychology behind the paywall, the surprise impact of raising prices, and what actually drove revenue at scale.

6.1 User Flow and Paywall Design

Glam Up User Flow (At a Glance):

1. Open the app
2. Welcome screens
3. Onboarding questions
4. "Leave a rating" page
5. "Analyzing your results" loading page
6. Home screen: select a scan

7. Upload or take a selfie
8. Fake scan animation plays
9. Blurred result pages are shown
10. Paywall/Referral choice is presented
11. Swiping paywall videos appear (if “See Your Results” is tapped)
12. User decision point

Step 1: Open the app

Glam Up launches immediately with no login screen, no “sign in with Google,” and no request for email or phone number. This was a strategic decision to eliminate all friction between the user and the core product. By removing account creation, we ensured that the highest number of users possible made it through to the paywall. The idea was simple: if someone’s curious enough to download the app, they should be able to get started without second-guessing. Momentum bias, the tendency for people to continue something once they’ve started, works in our favor here. Literature on freemium mobile apps (Yang et al., 2020; Seufert, 2022) supports this approach, showing that early friction like login screens or data capture significantly reduces conversion in products where emotional payoff happens later in the funnel. We didn’t want emails. We wanted users to get hooked.

Step 2: Welcome screens

After opening, users are greeted with three aesthetic welcome pages: “Glow up now,” “Discover your features,” and “Built by experts.” Each page features soft pink animated icons with short, encouraging captions. The visuals were intentionally designed to feel like a modern beauty brand — clean, minimal, and aspirational. This was our first chance to shape perception. We didn’t throw features at the user; we created a vibe. The goal here wasn’t education — it was

alignment. We wanted users to feel like this app got them, that it came from the same world as the beauty content they already trust.

Step 3: Onboarding questions

The onboarding flow follows immediately after the welcome screens. Users answer a short series of questions about their age, gender, beauty goals, skin concerns, and product preferences. Although none of these answers actually affect the scan results, they serve an important psychological purpose. By asking users to reflect on what they care about (whether they want to glow up, what types of products they use, or what concerns they have), we're priming them to become emotionally invested in whatever results we show next. This also subtly introduces the idea that Glam Up understands their individual needs, even though the backend doesn't yet tailor anything. It's all about perceived personalization — the feeling that this app isn't just for "beauty," but for *you*.

Step 4: "Leave a rating" page

Before users can proceed to the core product, they're shown a screen that reads: "Leave a rating! We're a small team, so a rating goes a really long way!" The only available button is "Leave a rating," which triggers the App Store review prompt. Once that closes, regardless of whether the user actually submitted a review, a second button appears: "I rated." This is the only way to continue. This design introduces a subtle psychological tension: users who didn't leave a rating must still click "I rated" to continue, effectively nudging them into either completing the review or momentarily "lying" to move forward. That moment of hesitation is intentional. It plays on consistency bias – the tendency for people to align their actions with prior choices in order to appear internally consistent (Cialdini, 2009) – and on moral friction – the discomfort people feel when their behavior doesn't align with their self-image as moral (Mazar et al., 2008).

Users, when faced with this choice, may go back and rate the app simply to feel honest. The request is low-effort, the guilt is minimal, and the placement (before any true product value is revealed) ensures that users are emotionally neutral and unlikely to push back. Framing it as a favor to a “small team” also taps into reciprocity bias, a well-documented social norm where people feel obligated to return a favor (Cialdini, 2009). Whether or not they actually submit a rating, the user walks away from the interaction feeling helpful and slightly more invested in what comes next.

Step 5: “Analyzing your results” loading page

After the rating screen, users arrive at a fake loading page that reads “Analyzing your results.” This screen appears for 5 seconds before revealing results, which are actually pre-determined based on onboarding answers. The real goal isn’t analysis. It’s suspense. This moment primes users to believe the app is doing something technically complex and valuable. Simulated computation like this is common in consumer apps, especially those rooted in AI or personalization. Research in human-computer interaction shows that when users experience a delay, even artificial, they perceive the result as more accurate and meaningful (Gray & Wegner, 2013; Langer et al., 1978). The act of waiting creates the illusion of depth, triggering the effort justification effect, the tendency to assign greater value to outcomes that required effort or delay (Aronson & Mills, 1959). It turns curiosity into anticipation and boosts perceived legitimacy.

Step 6: Home screen – select a scan

Once the fake analysis screen completes, users arrive at the home screen and are prompted to select one of three scans: Color Analysis, Glow Up Guide, or Facial Analysis. Each scan option includes a visual icon to help the user decide. This moment gives users a feeling of control, like they’re choosing their own path. This perceived autonomy has been shown to

increase emotional investment and satisfaction, even when the choices are superficial or lead to the same outcome (Iyengar & Lepper, 2000). Users also may feel like they're customizing their experience, even though every flow ultimately leads to the same core conversion point.

Step 7: Upload or take a selfie

After choosing a scan, users are asked to either take a photo or upload a selfie from their gallery. This is a powerful psychological moment: when a user uploads their own face, they cross a line between casual interest and personal involvement. There's now something at stake. They've made the experience about *themselves*. By placing this moment before the paywall, not after, we ensured that the user had already emotionally committed to the process. It was no longer a generic app; it was a mirror.

Step 8: Fake scan animation plays

Once the selfie is submitted, a scanning animation begins. But nothing is actually being processed yet. This scan is 100% fake, but the user doesn't know that. The animation wasn't added just for polish, but to make the moment feel real. We wanted the user to believe that something technical and valuable had just happened.

Step 9: Blurred result pages are shown

After the animation, the user is shown a multi-part results screen, but everything is blurred. The "Changes Needed" page is blurred. The personalized product list is blurred. Even the user's selfie is blurred. This is the emotional cliffhanger. The user can *see* that something's there, but they can't *access* it. And because they've already spent a few minutes answering questions, taking a photo, and watching a scan, they feel like they've earned the results. The blurring creates tension. The ambiguity keeps them moving. We designed the page to feel complete, but just out of reach.

Step 10: Paywall/Referral choice is presented

At the bottom of the blurred screen, two buttons appear: “See Your Results” or “Invite 3 Friends.” This is the moment of conversion, but we didn’t frame it as a subscription offer. We framed it as a natural next step in the journey the user already started. Either you pay to see your results now, or you refer friends and unlock it for free. Both paths let the user feel like they’re continuing something they already began instead of starting something new. That distinction matters.

Step 11: Swiping paywall videos appear

If the user taps “See Your Results,” they’re shown a three-part swiping video carousel, each designed to build emotional momentum, trust, and urgency. The first video is tailored specifically to the scan they chose. For example, if the user selected the Color Analysis Scan, they would see an animation video that mimics the actual scanning process, showing personalized color season & palette, colors to avoid, etc. This scan-specific video is there to re-trigger their curiosity and subtly reaffirm that they will get their results.

The second video is pure social proof: a fast-cut montage of creators showing the app, reacting to their results, and showing Glam Up like “I use this app a lot” or “wait this is insane”. We pulled these from our past influencer collaborations but stripped away their branding so they felt more like random people posting on TikTok. Overlaid with the caption “Viral on TikTok,” this video is designed to say: A LOT of people just like you are using this app and loving it.

The third video is a vertical scroll-through of dozens of 5-star app reviews that we designed directly in Figma. These reviews were crafted to reflect the most common emotional pain points: confusion at Sephora, spending so much money on random products, feeling like makeup never looks right, etc. The tone was distinctly Gen Z, full of slang, emojis, and broken

punctuation to feel like something you'd read on TikTok. The design was to show 1) high ratings and 2) Glam Up users feel like their own struggles were being understood and solved by Glam Up.

Each of these three videos serves a specific purpose: the first re-activates interest and builds perceived product legitimacy, the second creates social validation and urgency through TikTok virality cues, and the third hits emotional relatability and trust. Together, they form a layered persuasion sequence that doesn't feel like a sales pitch.

Step 12: User decision point

Finally, the user decides: pay, refer, or leave. But by this point, nearly every psychological lever has already been pulled. They've emotionally committed, invested effort, seen social validation, and built up anticipation for a result that feels uniquely theirs. We weren't selling a scan. We were offering closure. And for many users, that's what made the price feel worth it.

6.2 Pricing

When we first started thinking about how to monetize Glam Up, we didn't overcomplicate it. We had seen a few viral consumer apps start using weekly subscriptions instead of the more traditional monthly or annual plans. This trend is reflected in recent pricing reports that show increased adoption of short-cycle plans in mobile AI and wellness apps (Clevertap, 2022). It wasn't common yet, but it stood out. The format felt fast, emotional, and lightweight, which aligned with how our users made decisions — it feels more like buying a coffee or a lip gloss than committing to a subscription. That small psychological distinction mattered. We weren't trying to sell users a long-term membership. We were trying to convert a

moment of curiosity into a one-time “why not?” purchase. Weekly pricing gave us a format that matched the impulsive, aesthetic, and emotionally driven mindset we were building for.

Once we locked in the weekly model, we had to decide how much to charge — and again, we looked around. At the time, other scan-based or AI-driven apps were pricing weekly subscriptions anywhere between \$1.99 and \$6.99. We decided to start on the lower end: \$2.99/week for one scan, \$6.99/week for two scans, and \$8.99/week for four. Our thinking was pretty straightforward — we were a new app, we didn’t have brand trust yet, and we wanted the price to feel accessible. If someone was on the fence, we didn’t want cost to be the reason they bounced. Especially since the entire flow leading up to the paywall was designed to build emotional momentum, it felt important that the price didn’t interrupt that rhythm. We didn’t want people thinking, “Wait, is this worth it?” We wanted them to think, “It’s only a few bucks—I might as well try it.”

6.3 Emotional Timing, Price Increases, and Scan Upgrades

One of the things we added early on (and honestly it was kind of sneaky lol) was the second paywall. After users went through the scan and saw the full-price screen, if they clicked away, we immediately hit them with a 50% discounted version of the same offer. From the user’s perspective, it felt like they unlocked something by saying no. And that was exactly the point.

They’d just seen \$6.99. Now it was \$3.49. That contrast alone created this instinctive “Oh wait that’s way cheaper” reaction. It reframed the value of the app without us having to explain anything. Psychologically, it hit all the right levers: anchoring (the higher price made the discount feel better), loss aversion (they were about to walk away from something they were already invested in), and impulse timing (we caught them right as curiosity peaked).

At the time, we didn't fully realize how powerful that moment would be. We just thought, "Let's show a cheaper price and see if it helps." But it ended up becoming one of our strongest conversion tactics, especially because users were already a few minutes deep by that point. They'd taken a selfie, answered onboarding questions, and watched the scan animation. They were bought in emotionally. And when you're in that state, the sudden appearance of a better deal feels like a small win.

In July, we decided to raise prices. Honestly we didn't have massive data insight or a proper reason to do it. It was one of those "fuck it" moments. We raised the weekly prices to \$8.99, \$10.99, and \$12.99 for one, two, and four scans, while still keeping the intro offers in place for the first week. At the time, we were fully expecting conversion rates to drop. That's the usual logic—raise prices, see fewer signups, and hope the revenue balances out. We were preparing ourselves for that trade-off. But then... it didn't happen. In fact, conversions started going *up*. Not dramatically at first, but consistently. And by the time we hit November, we were sitting at a 5.5% average conversion rate—higher than before the price increase.

Table 1. Weekly Pricing Tiers for Glam Up Subscriptions

Metrics	April~July 2024	July~November 2024
1 scan weekly (offer)	\$2.99/week	\$8.99/week
2 scans weekly (offer)	\$6.99/week	\$10.99/week
4 scans weekly (offer)	\$8.99/week	\$12.99/week
1 scan weekly (intro_offer)	\$1.99/first week	\$4.49/first week
2 scans weekly (intro_offer)	\$3.49/first week	\$5.49/first week
4 scans weekly (intro_offer)	\$4.49/first week	\$6.49/first week
2 scans weekly (upgrade for more scans)	NA	+\$2
4 scans weekly (upgrade for more scans)	NA	+\$4
Conversion rate	3.5%	5.5%

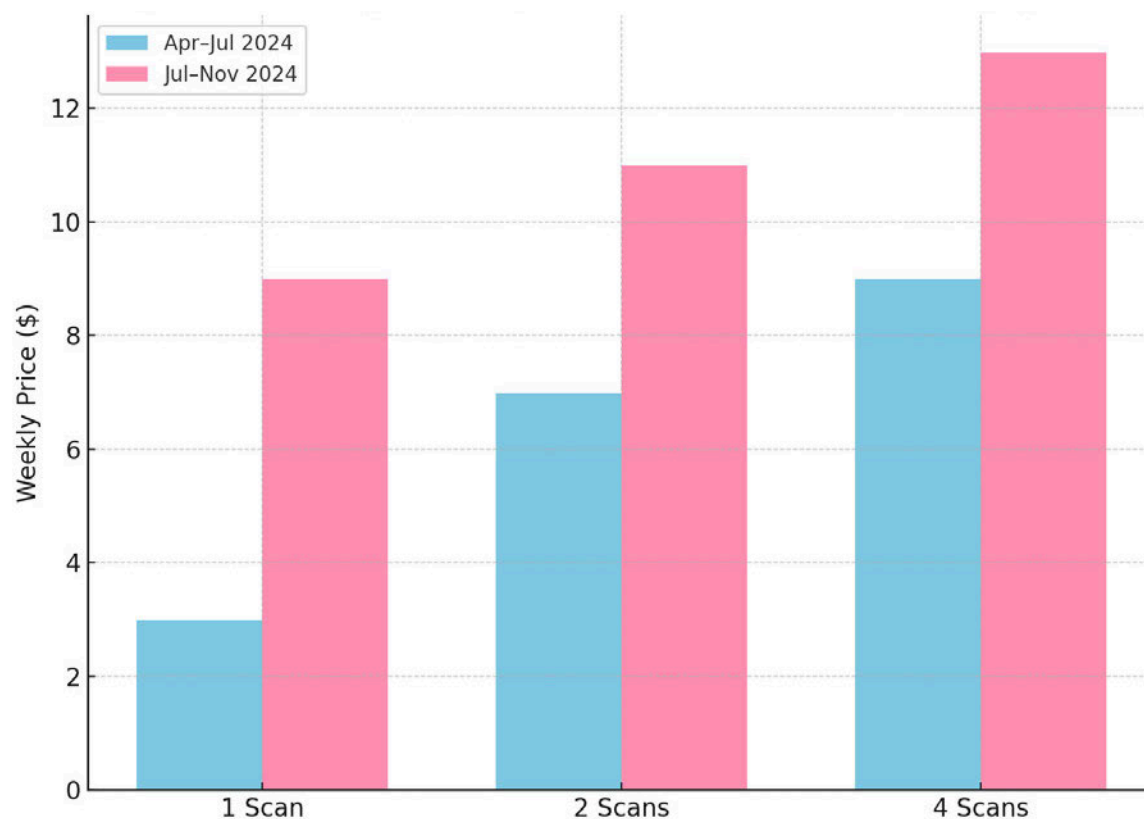
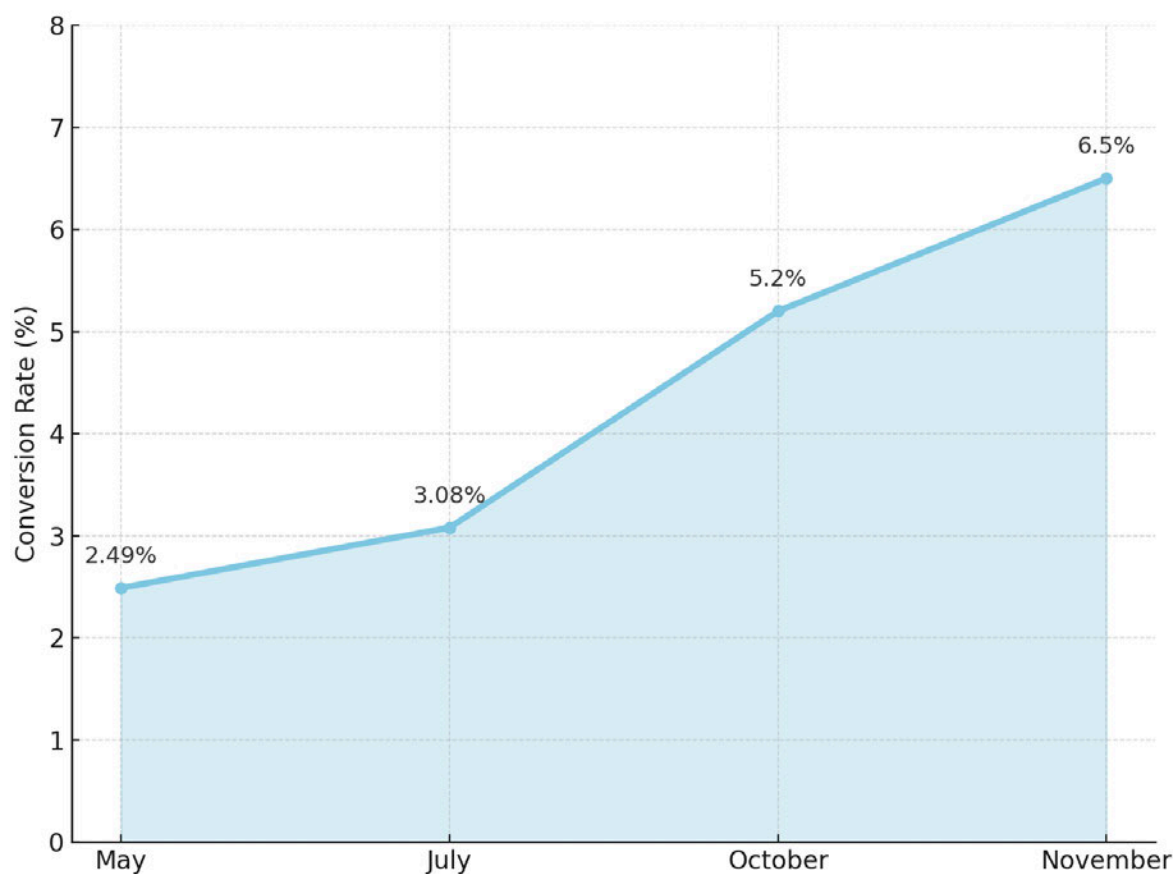
Figure 4. Weekly Subscription Prices: Before VS After July 2024

Figure 5. Paywall Conversion Rate Over Time (2024)

It didn't make sense at first. We hadn't changed the core product. The scans were mostly the same. But somehow, people were more willing to pay. Looking back, maybe it's because higher prices reframed the value of the app. This may align with behavioral economics findings that higher prices can act as a signal of higher value, influencing perception and willingness to pay (Ariely and Norton, 2009). At \$2.99, the scan might've felt like a novelty—something quick and fun to try. At \$8.99, it started to feel more like a real service. Same scan, different price, totally different perception. The product hadn't changed, but the way users experienced it might have. But to be honest, I don't have a clean explanation for why conversion improved. It still surprises me. It could've been the pricing, or maybe it was just good timing. Around that same period, our app store started getting more ratings. Maybe that made them trust it more. Maybe

they came in with higher intent. Maybe they were just more curious. I don't know exactly what happened, but something clicked, and conversions followed.

Around the same time, we introduced a scan upgrade option. If users were on a smaller plan—like one or two scans per week—we gave them the option to unlock more without fully switching tiers. For \$2, they could get two extra scans. For \$4, they could get four. It was a small test, but we figured some people are probably going to want to try again.

And they did, especially because Glam Up wasn't just a one-scan-and-done app. We had three completely different scans: Color Analysis, Glow Up Guide, and Facial Analysis. And within the Glow Up scan specifically, users could choose between six different makeup aesthetics, each with its own vibe, look, and step-by-step tutorial. So if someone came in wanting to try “Soft Grunge,” but then got curious about “Natural Glam” or “Latina Baddie,” the desire to explore was designed into the experience.

The upgrade option made it easy to act on that curiosity without having to commit to a higher subscription tier. No complicated pricing menus or new decisions, just a small, optional add-on. It was still emotionally driven, quick, and lightweight, just like the core subscription. And while it didn't become a massive revenue driver, it matched how people were actually using the app: casually, playfully, and often after seeing a TikTok that inspired them to try something new.

What I've learned from all of this is that monetization isn't just about pricing models or where you place the paywall. It's about timing, framing, and how people feel in the moment they're deciding to pay. For Glam Up, weekly pricing likely worked not because it was the most strategic plan on paper, but because it matched the emotional rhythm of our users. It felt casual.

Disposable. Immediate. And when you build something rooted in impulse, you have to monetize in a way that respects the impulse instead of slowing it down.

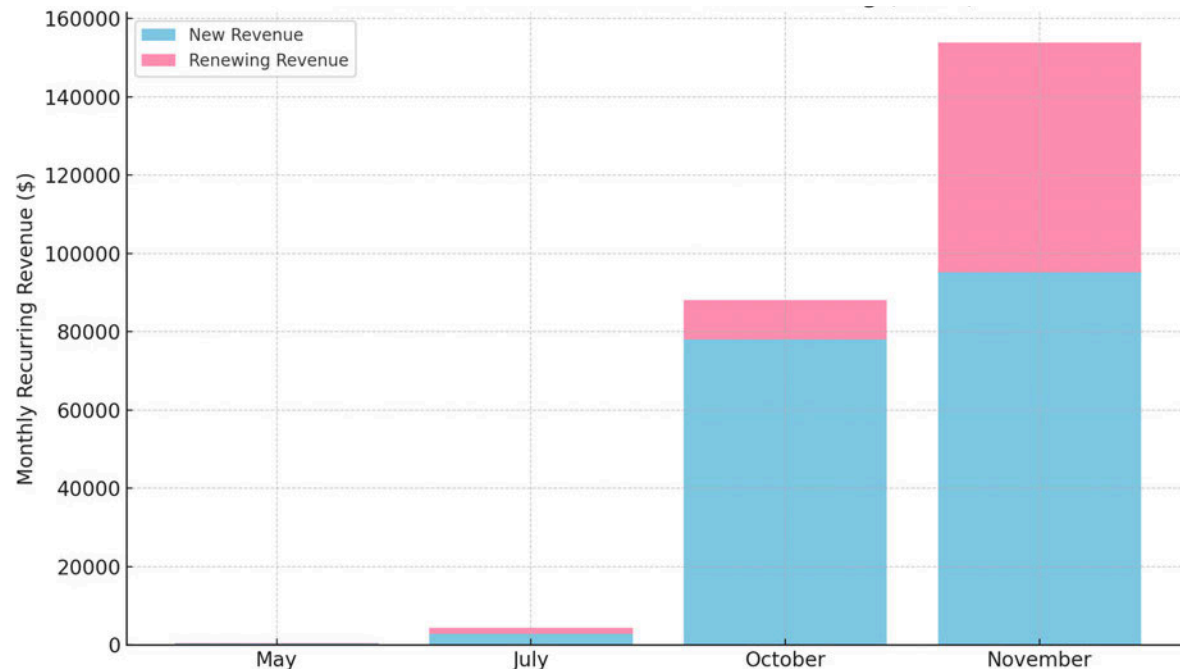
6.4 Results: Revenue and Conversion Trends

This section only covers metrics from May to November 2024, which reflects the core six-month period when most of Glam Up’s growth and experimentation occurred. The main thing the metrics show is that growth wasn’t instant — it built slowly, then spiked hard. Our conversion rates started low (2.49% in May), and only started to climb after we made changes to paywall timing, pricing tiers, and emotional framing. But realistically, a huge part of the growth came from TikTok. Once we started going viral, everything compounded. By November, we were converting 6.5% of users who hit the paywall and had passed \$150K in MRR. Renewing revenue also became a big deal. In May, it was basically a rounding error. By November, it made up more than 60% of our total MRR. Whether that’s because users actually loved the product or just forgot to cancel... honestly probably the latter one.

Table 2. Monthly Revenue Metrics on iOS (excluding Android)

Note: All subscription revenue is recurring

Month (2024)	New Subscription Revenue	Renewing Revenue	Total MRR	Conversion Rate
May	\$372	\$137	\$509	2.49%
July	\$2,747	\$1,639	\$4,386	3.08%
October	\$77,955	\$10,138	\$88,093	5.2%
November	\$95,186	\$58,733	\$153,919	6.5%

Figure 6. Revenue Breakdown: New VS. Renewing (2024)

The point is: we didn't scale by having one perfect growth tactic. We scaled because a bunch of little things started working at the same time. And when they stacked, they really stacked.

6.5 Timing Is Everything

Monetization wasn't something we nailed on day one. It was a slow, messy process of testing, guessing, watching behavior, and adjusting over and over again. Some things worked better than expected—like the second paywall. Some things made no sense at all—like how raising prices actually helped. But the biggest unlock wasn't any one tactic. It was realizing that how and when you ask someone to pay matters way more than what you're charging.

Everything we did (weekly pricing, emotional setup, surprise discounts) was about timing the ask to when the user actually *felt* something. And once we got that right, it scaled exponentially.

Looking back, it's clear that if we hadn't figured out those smaller details before going viral, the outcome could've been completely different. The same TikTok momentum that helped us reach \$150K in MRR could've just as easily led to \$100K, or even less, if our paywall, pricing, and upgrades weren't optimized to catch users in that exact emotional moment. Getting the mechanics right *before* the growth spike let us actually capitalize on it.

7. Marketing

7.1 Timeline

Table 3. Glam Up Growth Timeline and Key Milestones (2024)

Time (2024)	What the chart says	What was actually happening
March 28th	Idea born	Just over the moon about starting an app (very naive)
April	App launched	Half-broken launch, but at least we launched it
May	1st user	Tried influencer marketing. Flopped. ROI was negative. Mostly just fixing bugs.
June~July	Growth hacks	Discovered faceless beauty accounts. Got the first 1M viewed TikTok. Still stuck at ~\$10K MRR.
July~August	\$31 on App Store, 100K downloads, Version 2.0 Launch	No idea what to do next. Burnt out. Tried 5 random things a week. Nothing really clicked.
September	200K downloads, 4K+ ratings on US App Store	In the last days of September, UGC started to work. We trained creators, and content finally started converting.
October	700K downloads, #3 on App Store, Version 3.0 Launch	The content started going viral
November	1M+ downloads, 16K+ reviews on US App Store, 150K MRR	Very happy and focused on scaling. 40~50M views on TikTok in 30 days

As we were still trying to figure out the app itself (fixing bugs, redesigning onboarding, reworking scans), we were also struggling with marketing. We weren't aiming for "just run ads" kind of growth. We wanted the kind that felt real: organic, viral, and user-driven, like people were actually excited to use the app and tell their friends about it.

From the outside, it might look like Glam Up took off fast. But that's not how it felt at the moment. There was no grand strategy. Just a lot of trial and error. Most of our early growth experiments flopped, especially influencer marketing.

Initially, Glam Up relied heavily on influencer marketing, reaching out to hundreds of influencers. This process required building extensive email campaigns and follow-up sequences, which was a steep learning curve in itself to try different tools. However, many influencers, especially those within agencies, charged ridiculous rates that were definitely ROI-negative. I also tried switching to many online tools for finding creators. However, most of them primarily listed agency-affiliated influencers, compounding the challenge. We had to shift to manual searches, prioritizing influencers using personal email domains like gmail or outlook to avoid agency markups.

Negotiating favorable terms was hard too. On top of that, many influencers lacked experience in promoting apps, leading to inconsistent content performance. As a result, we experimented with multiple strategies, but influencer marketing did not yield the expected ROI, prompting a strategic pivot.

After months of battling inconsistent ROI from influencer collaborations, Glam Up experienced a turning point. It started with a single \$10 TikTok post from a faceless beauty account—an account with no face, no voice, and no personal brand. Just clean, aesthetic content.

The post wasn't polished at all. It was just a boring, long video going through a Glam Up tutorial (how to use the app).

The post generated over 1 million views in three days. It drove thousands of new users to the app. The comment section was also flooded with people commenting their referral code from the app to get the app for free. What started as a one-time \$10 experiment quickly snowballed into a viral loop with exponential reach and nearly zero acquisition cost.

We immediately doubled down.

We started reaching out to more faceless beauty pages on both TikTok and Instagram, offering \$5–\$15 per post. It worked. Within weeks, we were pulling in over \$10,000 MRR, driven almost entirely by organic content and referral loops. But it wasn't breakout growth yet. It was steady. Promising. But not explosive. The posts were working, but we were still figuring out why some went viral and others flopped. Some days, we'd gain thousands of users. Other days, nothing. We hadn't yet built a system. We were riding momentum, but we weren't driving it.

One morning in late October, we saw a sudden spike in app downloads. Not a small bump—tens of thousands of new users were pouring in. At first, we assumed one of our usual beauty accounts had just posted something that blew up. But there was nothing new. No explosive paid promo, and no trending video from any of our official partners. Just a silent explosion in traffic.

We started digging.

We checked our accounts' videos, explored trending TikTok hashtags, and scrolled through comments on our recent posts. That's when we noticed something strange: random TikTok users were commenting their Glam Up referral codes under our content, but not in

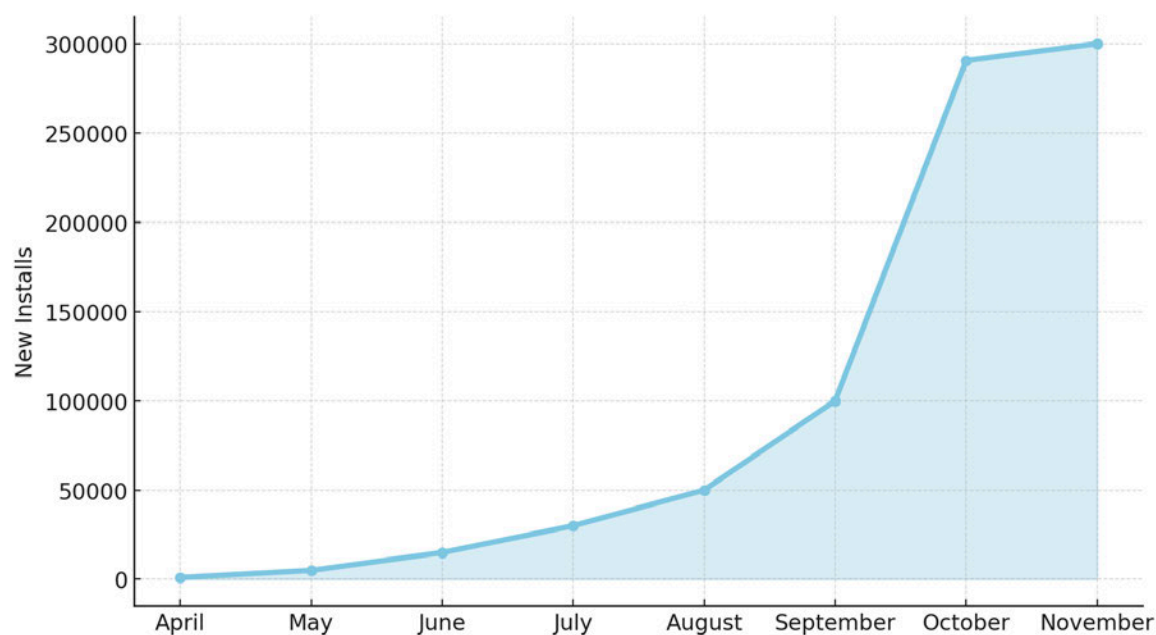
response to anything we had posted. So we started DMing them. Dozens of them. We asked where they had seen Glam Up, what video it came from, and who posted it.

And that's when we found it.

A complete copycat app called Glam AI posted a before-and-after picture of a random girl and told people to download Glam AI. However, Glam AI had no presence on the App Store and the name was so similar to ours that everyone downloaded our app instead. We immediately recreated the same format, this time with Glam Up branding. The video hit 1+ million views and got us 30K+ users in 24 hours. In that week, that video got 10 million views, and we made over \$100K.

Figure 7. Viral TikTok Format That Drove 30K+ Users in 24 Hours



Figure 8. Monthly New User Growth (2024)

This was the tipping point. We weren't just riding momentum anymore. We had proof: the format was replicable, and we knew how to trigger virality on command.

7.2 The Playbook

When our Glam Up-branded recreation of the Glam AI post hit 10 million views in one week, we didn't overthink it. We studied the hell out of it and replicated it. We opened up a bunch of fresh TikTok accounts, warmed them up, and started pumping out variations of the format. Here are the metrics we've tested:

1. Racial and ethnic diversity in "models" – We found that videos featuring Latina and White girls with certain facial features performed best when paired with bold before-and-after reveals.
2. Contrast level between "before" and "after" – The greater the transformation, the higher the share rate. We intentionally chose and edited very ugly "before" pictures and maximized contrast in the "after" glow-up picture.

3. Placement and size of the hook text – Small hooks on the side of the screen performed better with very specific text (“never saw myself with the right makeup routine”).
4. Emoji usage – Emojis boosted performance. For example, 🌟 and 🧖‍♀️ were the best emojis to use compared to other ones like 😊.
5. Captions and hashtags – Caption phrasing like “I would be unstoppable” worked the best compared to other captions like “the glow up I deserve” or other variations we’ve tried. Hashtags like #makeuptransformation, #beforeandafter, #viralpost, #fyp and #makeuptutorials outperformed other ones like #makeuptok or #girltok.
6. Posting times – Early evening (6–10 PM local time) yielded the highest views, especially when paired with trending audios.

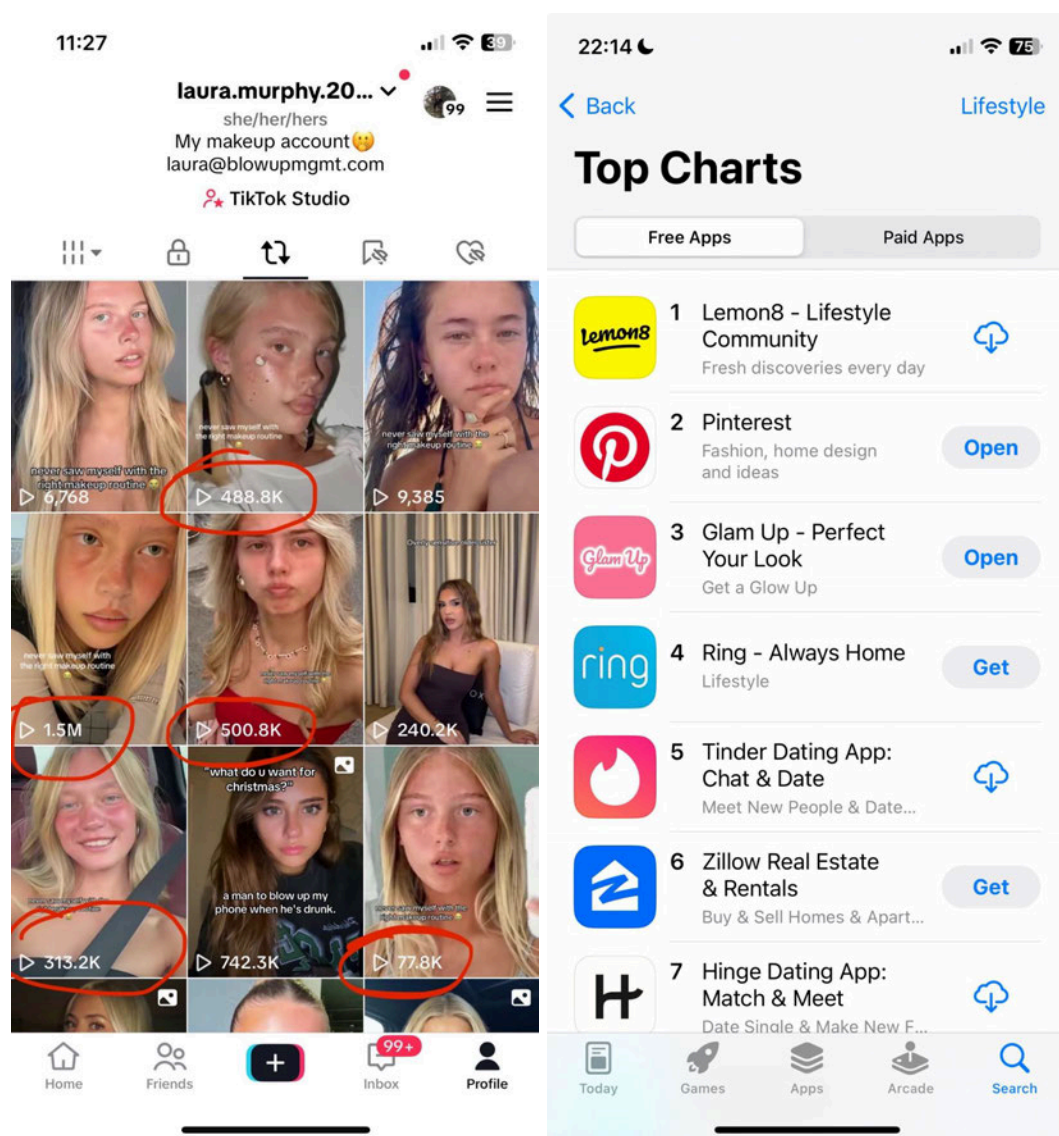
By standardizing this process, we created a repeatable system, one where even brand-new creators consistently hit thousands or millions of views. Then, we got to scaling. We onboarded around 6 UGC creators (college students), and paid them each \$400/month plus a conservative bonus structure. We didn’t just ask creators to make content — we taught them how to grow accounts from zero using tested viral strategies. The program included:

1. Warm-up tactics to boost algorithm favorability before launching a Glam Up post.
2. Specific script formats and visual structures proven to perform well on TikTok’s FYP algorithm (e.g. “POV hooks,” glow-up transformations, and face-scan suspense reveals).
3. Step-by-step editing techniques for maximizing retention using pacing, captions, and call-to-actions.

For many of these new accounts, their first week of posting already generated over 500K views. During our best month, we generated 40~50 million views on TikTok alone in 30 days. This also led us to #3 on the US App Store for Lifestyle. This system allowed Glam Up to scale

content production without burning budget on paid ads or big-name partnerships. The result: a compounding traffic loop where every creator became part of the engine. But most importantly, we constantly tested and iterated. To get to the point where \$400/month creators were driving millions of views, we broke down every piece of content into testable variables and optimized aggressively.

Figure 9. UGC Creator Performance and App Store Ranking



7.3 Things that didn't work

Now that we've covered what worked, I think it's even more important to talk about what didn't. For every viral video and growth loop that scaled, there were many things that flopped, underperformed, or wasted time and money. Here's the stuff we tested—and won't be doing again anytime soon.

1. Influencer Marketing: A Whole Lot of Effort for Nothing

We started with the obvious: influencer marketing. I spent weeks building out email campaigns and outreach databases, trying every tool — Modash, Upfluence, Collabstr, and scraping TikTok bios manually.

Our hit rate was already low, but even when we booked influencers, the results were underwhelming. One creator with 150K followers charged up to \$10,000 for a single video. It would get 100K views and maybe 200 users. Others may just completely ghost after signing an agreement.

We also discovered the platform tooling problem. Tools like Modash are dominated by agency-affiliated influencers — people who charge 5–10x more because they have representation. We ended up manually filtering creators by email domain just to find non-agency ones (look for @gmail or @outlook = usually safe). But even that didn't guarantee results.

Many influencers also didn't know how to talk about apps. They knew how to talk about beauty products, Amazon finds, or daily routines, but converting a swipe into a download and referral was a different game. The call to action was unclear, and many didn't show the scan or results at all. The content looked like an ad, and it didn't spark curiosity or emotion.

However, I want to mention that influencer marketing *can* work, especially for brands and lifestyle products. It has worked well for apps like Finch or BeReal, which relied on

community-based sharing or hype. It just didn't fit our early-stage needs, where ROI had to be immediate and consistent.

Another influencer model that *has* proven effective for other apps in our space: equity-based partnerships with deeply aligned creators.

We've seen this work especially well when:

1. The influencer is *natively embedded* in the product's niche (e.g. a skincare creator for a skincare app)
2. They have deep trust with their audience and post organically—not just once, but as an ongoing narrative
3. They feel emotionally or reputationally invested in the product's success (equity helps here)

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

Another example is [REDACTED], a beauty transformation app that scaled rapidly by partnering with a fitness and beauty influencer with 1M+ followers. I was doing a lot of digging when they went viral (I was scared they were going to come after Glam Up), and found that instead of doing a flat-rate paid promo, the influencer took a minor equity cut and posted skits

showing the app. The app went viral in 1 day and surged to 10K MRR. However, I haven't heard from them since.

Why this model works:

It combines the reach of influencer marketing, the credibility of founder-led marketing, and the long-term incentive alignment of startup culture. When done right, it doesn't feel like a promo—it feels like the creator is building something for their own community.

Why it didn't work for us (yet):

We didn't have close personal ties to any creator who deeply aligned with Glam Up. Cold outreach wasn't enough. And without an existing trust bridge, offering equity didn't make sense. It's a strategy that works best when the influencer is already excited about the mission or personally invested in the problem.

2. Faceless Accounts: Cheap Reach Isn't Enough

Our first real moment of traction came from a faceless TikTok post. A creator we paid just \$10 posted a simple tutorial about Glam Up, and hit over 1 million views. That single post kicked off a viral loop that brought in thousands of new users, and for a brief moment, it made faceless beauty accounts look like the perfect growth strategy.

But as we quickly learned, that post was an outlier.

Encouraged by the results, we tried to scale the approach across both Instagram and TikTok. On Instagram, we partnered with over 50 faceless beauty pages — accounts that post aesthetic content with no personal brand. We paid \$5–\$15 per post and were able to quickly build a network of accounts pushing Glam Up content. These pages got decent engagement; some posts reached 500K+ views. But conversions were low. Particularly on Instagram, most of their

audience came from India, Pakistan, or Southeast Asia — lower income, Android users who don't convert well. Even when we saw app installs, they rarely led to subscriptions or revenue.

Instagram's faceless account space was cheap and easy to access, but the quality of the traffic didn't align with our monetization goals. Most of the beauty accounts on Instagram are actually run by Indian men, resourceful hustlers who saw Instagram as a side hustle. They didn't care about Glam Up, didn't understand beauty, and didn't know how to communicate value. We had to provide fully produced videos, written captions, and monitor content quality constantly. However, once we got a few accounts onboard, it became exponentially easier to scale. The network is tight-knit; if one account works with you, others follow. We even reached 1M+ follower pages with little effort once we had some social proof. For pure visibility and seeding awareness, this strategy still has value. But it wasn't built for high-quality user acquisition.

On TikTok, the dynamic was different. The platform is banned in India, so most faceless accounts are based in the U.S., Canada, or Europe. That means higher rates, often 3–10x what Instagram creators charged. Many of these creators also aren't doing it as a side hustle but more like a hobby, which also meant creators were harder to reach, more inconsistent, and less responsive. Most of the accounts we reached out to never replied. Others would agree to collaborations but would ghost afterwards. We quickly realized we were paying a premium for creators who didn't care and had no proven way to drive results.

Even the creator who posted our first viral \$10 video couldn't replicate it. Many posts she made afterward flopped. This was a consistent pattern. TikTok faceless accounts tend to spike once, then fade. The lack of a recurring face or voice makes it harder for them to build real engagement. The algorithm rewards momentum, but these accounts were too volatile to build around.

By late 2024, saturation made things worse. Dozens of other apps started flooding the same faceless accounts. AI makeup apps, color analysis app, motivational apps were all flooding into the Instagram faceless account space and driving the market rate up. The audience also got overwhelmed. Engagement dropped. And what once looked like organic beauty content started to feel like back-to-back sponsored spam.

In the end, faceless accounts — both on TikTok and Instagram — played an important role in Glam Up's early days. They helped us test formats, seed content, and hit our first viral spike. But they weren't scalable, repeatable, or reliable. They offered reach, but not revenue. Visibility, but not trust.

Real growth didn't happen when we rented distribution from creators we didn't know. It happened when we built our own engine — one we could control, optimize, and scale.

3. Celebrity Glow Up Content

We ran several TikTok slideshows and video posts featuring celebrity transformations, like “What's Zendaya's color palette?” or “Taylor Swift before vs. after having her beauty consultants.” These videos looked great and often pulled in decent reach — anywhere from 10K to 50K views. But they rarely converted. People watched, maybe even saved or liked the post, but didn't follow through to download the app. These posts felt more like entertainment than activation. They didn't spark that key emotional reaction of “this could be me.” There was no personal relevance or urgency, just curiosity at best. That said, celebrity-based content still has a place. It can help establish brand credibility and aesthetics. Some of our best top-of-funnel videos included celebrity references and performed well from a visibility standpoint. It just didn't translate to conversions for us.

Apps like Lensa AI succeeded with celebrity-style content because they didn't stop at showing famous faces—they gave users the *tools to see themselves* in that same glow-up narrative. Their success wasn't just about aesthetics; it was about personalization and participation. By combining high-impact visual effects with shareable outputs and viral mechanics, like posting your own “Magic Avatar” or AI-enhanced version. They made the experience feel aspirational and actionable. People weren't just admiring someone else's transformation; they were actively engaging in their own.

That's where our celebrity content fell short. Without that same interactive hook or identity-based outcome, our slideshows became just another pretty video. They sparked passive curiosity, but not emotional urgency. There was no “I need to try this now” moment. And on TikTok, where content moves fast and emotional triggers matter, that's the difference between a scroll-past and a download.

For celebrity content to truly convert, it has to go beyond recognition. It has to invite users to imagine themselves in that transformation. Without that personal payoff, it doesn't matter how beautiful or well-produced the content is. It won't drive meaningful growth.

7.4 The Value of What Didn't Work

Looking back, none of these failures were wasted. Each misstep taught us something foundational. These experiments revealed what didn't work *for us*, at *our stage*, with *our users*. And that clarity is priceless.

We didn't learn by sitting in a strategy room guessing what might work. We learned by trying, failing, and adjusting quickly. That \$10 TikTok post didn't happen because we were smart—it happened because we were willing to test everything until something clicked. And

once it clicked, we didn't romanticize the discovery. We broke it down, rebuilt it into a system, and scaled it deliberately.

In consumer apps, especially ones built around identity and aesthetics like Glam Up, growth doesn't come from copying trends or hiring expensive creators. It comes from deep alignment between product, psychology, and content format. None of the flops detailed here were bad ideas in general—they just weren't the right fit for *this* app, *at this time*, with *this audience*.

8. What Next?

After Glam Up's viral moment, after the 150K MRR and 40~50 million views in November 2024, we didn't try to push it further. Not really.

After Glam Up's initial virality, we maintained ~\$100K MRR for about two months before revenue began to taper. By March 2025, our MRR stabilized at around \$40K, largely driven by continued views from past viral content. Interestingly, many of our most successful TikToks didn't die out after a few weeks. They've continued to accumulate views over time, keeping our acquisition pipeline passively alive even without new experiments. We've maintained a consistent posting schedule with creators, but haven't launched major new campaigns since November 2024.

During this time, over 10 similar beauty AI apps launched, many of them clearly inspired by Glam Up. But none, aside from the brief confusion-driven virality of Glam AI, have achieved meaningful traction or cultural relevance. The space feels saturated now, and while the concept still draws curiosity, the novelty that once drove explosive growth is fading.

There were obvious next steps. We could've scaled the content engine, built a 100-person UGC army, and leaned into every growth lever available to consumer apps in this space. We talked about launching an affiliate program. We had early conversations with major brands in beauty and skincare who were excited to collaborate. I even reached out to Charli D'Amelio's talent agency – multiple managers replied and were genuinely down to explore celebrity-backed content partnerships.

We also explored the monetization path through product recommendations. Since Glam Up was already generating personalized beauty routines and AI-powered product lists, it made sense to integrate with retailers or brands directly. A few big names were open to the idea. If we had moved faster, we probably could've built an affiliate-based DTC channel or partnered with legacy beauty brands looking for a Gen Z edge.

But... we didn't.

We didn't double down. We didn't raise funding. We didn't hire a growth team or chase partnerships. And the truth is: I think both me and my co-founder were just tired. Not burnt out exactly, but we missed the 0 to 1 phase. The part where you're figuring something out for the first time, not trying to optimize what's already working. The messy, uncertain, late-night energy of making something out of nothing.

Once the formula was working, it became... less fun. Less creative. More like running a playbook than building something new.

And honestly, part of it was the business model itself. Glam Up wasn't built to retain — it was built to explode. Users paid per scan, which meant revenue was front-loaded. But that also meant they had little reason to keep coming back after a few tries. To become a truly sticky, long-term app, we would've needed to invest way more into engineering and product: better

journaling tools, more interactive content, smarter personalization, retention mechanics, community features. At some point, we started seeing Glam Up more like a [REDACTED] — in the sense that the business model was designed for quick bursts of attention and cash, not long-term habit. Turning it into a sustainable project was doable. But to us, it wasn't really worth building — especially if we could already use Glam Up as a cash cow to fund the next project.

And personally, I didn't want to wake up and spend my day negotiating brand deals, managing creators, or navigating celebrity managers' calendars. I didn't want to turn Glam Up into a CPG tool or a content house. Even though it could've been a solid business. Even though we had traction most people would kill for.

So... We stopped scaling before the sprint turned into a marathon we didn't want to run.

There's something addictive about early-stage building. When every day feels like it could be the day something takes off. When you're testing 10 ideas a week, pulling late nights because you're curious, not obligated. That's what I loved. Not maintaining a system, but making sense of chaos.

Glam Up gave me that in spades. It taught me how consumer apps grow, what virality feels like, how users behave, and how fast everything can change when you get the right moment. But it also taught me to pay attention to *my own energy*. What kind of builder I want to be. What kind of problems I want to solve.

After stepping back from Glam Up, we built again. But this time, my co-founder and I didn't want to just run one app. We wanted to build a system that could launch many. A repeatable infrastructure for going from idea → prototype → traction — fast. An app studio! One

that could take what I learned from Glam Up and apply it to different problems, different verticals, different playbooks.

That's how Prep AI started.

Prep AI is "Tinder" for jobs – swipe on jobs and we automatically apply for you on the company website. We launched it about three months ago, and as I write this in April 2025, we just hit our first viral loop. We're sitting at ~\$10K MRR and climbing fast.

A lot of what's working now are strategies I've already shared in this thesis: emotional hooks, thoughtful onboarding sequence, performance-based UGCs, and viral mechanics that feel native to the platform. It's surreal watching the same playbook come to life in a totally different vertical.

Different product, same energy: start fast, test hard, stay close to the user, and let the internet surprise you!

9. Playbook and Mindset

Most people overcomplicate virality. They think it's about luck, timing, or having the perfect product. It's not. Going viral is a system, and staying viral is a mindset. This section breaks down both: the playbook that helped Glam Up scale to over a million users from May to November of 2024, and the mentality you actually need to survive building something from scratch.

Playbook

1. Pick an Industry with Platform-Native Virality

Before building anything, spend time researching what kinds of topics already perform well on the platform you plan to grow on. For example, beauty and dating

dominate TikTok because they're visual, emotional, and easy to relate to. In contrast, crypto has huge traction on Twitter but barely makes a dent on TikTok (just search “crypto” in both platforms and you'll see the difference). This means even the best crypto app might flop if you try to grow it on TikTok.

Don't just choose a “hot” industry—choose one that people are already creating content about on the platform you're targeting. TikTok has mass consumer reach, so if you want to go viral there, start with what people are already watching, posting, and sharing.

2. Design for shareability, not just functionality (sometimes functionality doesn't matter at all, RIP)

Your app should look good in screenshots, videos, or someone's story—not just function well behind the scenes. The most viral apps aren't always the best *products*—they're the ones people want to post about. That means designing features that are visual, satisfying, or surprising enough to make someone say, “Wait, I need to show this.”

A perfectly functioning product that doesn't trigger emotion or curiosity won't go viral. A slightly janky app with a killer before/after moment or a trend-friendly result? That might.

3. Don't Marry a Marketing Strategy Until It Proves Itself

Different products go viral in different ways. Some blow up through faceless accounts. Others need a loud creator personality or a perfectly timed trend. The only way to know what works for *your* app is to try everything—UGC creators, influencers, meme pages, aesthetic montages, whatever.

The good news? If it works, you'll know fast. TikTok/Instagram either picks it up or it doesn't. So don't sit around waiting to feel "ready." Just try, fail fast, and when something hits, double down like crazy.

4. Turn Marketing Into a System

Virality isn't luck. Once you find a format that works, turn it into a playbook. Script the hooks. Standardize the visuals. Train your creators. Make content creation so repeatable that anyone on your team could do it.

5. Scale

Just focus on execution for this.

Mindset

1. Be Delusional

If you scroll through Twitter long enough, you'll notice that every tech bro, founder, and early-stage builder swears by one thing — delusional faith. The idea that you have to believe irrationally hard in something before the world gives you a reason to. Accept the reality that at the beginning, nobody cares. You have no data, no traction, and probably no idea what you're doing. You just have belief. And belief is what gets you to take the first 10 swings when logic says you shouldn't. You don't need validation to begin. You just need delusional faith.

Honestly, I think early-stage success is just a proxy for how delusional you're willing to be, and whether you can back it up with grit, experimentation, and obsession. Your faith shows in your actions. If you really believe in what you're building, it'll show up in how many things you test, how hard you listen to users, and how many nights you spend trying to prove yourself right. Or wrong.

2. Growth Over Ego

Don't worry about being right. Worry about learning fast. Treat every post, launch, and feature like an experiment. If it flops, learn. If it hits, scale. Growth happens when you stop making it about your ego.

3. Question Everything (F*k What Everyone Else Says)

Just because something is “best practice” doesn't mean it's right for you. Most of the playbooks you see online are outdated, built for B2B SaaS or boomer consumer apps. The AI consumer space is new—and most of the people winning right now are Gen Z builders in their 20s, sometimes not even engineers.

You're not supposed to listen to VCs or the older generation when it comes to social media growth. It's not that *you* know best — it's that *nobody* knows. This space is too new for gatekeeping. If something doesn't make sense, rip it apart. Build from first principles. That's how you find your edge.

4. 80-20 Rule

The 80/20 rule, also known as the Pareto Principle, states that roughly 80% of outcomes come from 20% of inputs. In startups, that means 80% of your growth, retention, or revenue usually stems from a small fraction of your inputs (app idea, product feature, paywall design, content formats, etc.) (Koch, 1999). The hard part is identifying that 20%—and having the discipline to ignore the rest.

That 20% might be luck. But you can always try to maximize the surface area of your luck. Experiment fast, test wide, and stay close to your users. Luck favors builders who try more, ship more, and reflect more. In the early stages, it's tempting to optimize everything: every screen, every flow, every feature. But virality often comes from one

hook that hits. Retention comes from one loop that sticks. Revenue comes from one flow that converts.

5. Focus On Big Swings

Me and my co-founder always ask ourselves one question when we try something different: “Is this a big swing?” If it’s not, we don’t even bother trying. Big swings are bets that, if they work, change the game. A new content format. A viral growth mechanic. A paywall design that may convert way better. Not every swing will land. But when one does, it will do more for your app than 100 tiny tweaks ever could.

It’s our way of checking whether we’re chasing the kind of idea that could actually change the trajectory of our app, or just over-optimizing a small feature that no one really cares about.

Early on, it’s easy to get stuck tweaking button colors, rewriting tooltips, or reordering onboarding questions. But those things usually aren’t the reason your app grows. They’re not your 20%. They’re the noise. And when you’re building with limited time and energy, you need to swing big.

6. Confidence Is Earned, Not Felt

You don’t need to feel confident to start. You just need to do the thing. Real confidence isn’t a mindset, it’s muscle memory. It comes from doing something enough times that it stops feeling scary. It’s built through small wins, daily reps, and putting yourself in motion even when you’re unsure.

Most people wait to feel ready. But the truth is, confidence shows up after you act—not before. If you already feel confident before doing the hard part, that’s not

confidence, it's ego. And ego gets fragile fast when reality hits. Earned confidence, on the other hand, is resilient. It's built through reps, feedback, and showing up consistently.

7. Confusion Is Normal. Keep Going Anyway

You're going to feel lost half the time. That doesn't mean you're doing it wrong. It means you're in the middle of figuring it out. Most people quit in confusion. Don't be most people.

8. Humility > Praise

Don't try to make something impressive. Make something people actually want to talk about. It's rarely the one that looks smartest, but the one that makes people feel something that blows up. Focus on that.

On a personal note, I've never liked it when people say "I'm proud of you." I know it's meant with kindness, but it's always felt off to me. Maybe it's because I've wrestled with my own relationship to external validation. How can I feel validated by someone who doesn't know wtf I went through to get here? How can I feel validated by someone else when I don't even feel that way internally?

That's why I try to build from a place of humility, not performance. Not to impress anyone. Not to chase approval. But to make something out of nothing.

Something that's real. And in the process, maybe I'll feel proud of it too.

10. Last Words

"We are told to remember the idea, not the man. Because a man can fail. He can be caught, he can be killed and forgotten. But 400 years later, an idea can still change the world."

– V for Vendetta, 2006

Find an idea. Something that resonates with you so deeply, it carries you through the moments when you want to give up. That one idea alone can pull you out of the darkest, most anxious stretches.

When I was in the trenches growing Glam Up, I just *really* needed Glam Up to do well as if my life depended on it. I didn't care if it was irrational. I didn't even know exactly why at first. But I think it was my inner child fighting to matter.

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

I ended up going to college for psychology and economics. I got really into psychedelics, spirituality, and human behavior. I found a lot of it fascinating, some of it even healing. But nothing hit quite the same. I [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] [REDACTED] So when I started building Glam Up, I think a part of me [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] I

had to prove that I could still do something beautiful.

There are so many people more talented than me. People who could've done what I did, probably better. But the opportunity landed on me. And I didn't want to feel like I wasted it

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

[REDACTED]

Steve Jobs said a quote I really like: “You can’t connect the dots looking forward; you can only connect them looking backward. So you have to trust that the dots will somehow connect in your future (Jobs, 2005).” I really look forward to that day. I think when you’re on the right path, even if it’s messy, uncertain, or hard, the universe gives you signs. Little moments that feel too aligned to be random. A conversation that happens at the right time. An opportunity that lands exactly when you need it. A feeling in your gut that tells you to keep going, even when everyone or everything else says stop.

Sometimes, what drives you isn’t logic or ambition or even clarity. Sometimes, it’s just a feeling. A thread to your younger self. A need to make it all mean something. That’s what kept me going.

11. Limitation

This thesis is based on what we built, tested, and observed while scaling Glam Up, but like any case study grounded in a real-world startup, it comes with its own limitations.

First, the data. When we first launched Glam Up, we didn’t have sophisticated analytics pipelines or detailed attribution tracking. We relied on tools like App Store Developer Console, PostHog and Superwall, but our setup wasn’t perfect — and many of the insights in this thesis are based on directional patterns, not airtight experiments. Some of the metrics, especially from the earliest growth periods, are rough estimates drawn from a combination of memory,

screenshots, and scattered event tracking. If we had set things up more rigorously from the beginning, the data would be cleaner — but that’s not how startups work.

Second, this isn’t a universal playbook. What worked for Glam Up might not work for your app, especially if you’re in a different vertical, target a different demographic, or operate under different constraints. Beauty is an unusually visual, emotionally reactive category that thrives on platforms like TikTok. Our viral mechanics, pricing psychology, and content systems were deeply tied to the cultural context of Gen Z beauty trends in 2024. If you’re building a meditation app or a productivity tool, you probably shouldn’t copy this exactly. The principles might carry over, but the execution might differ. That said, part of why Glam Up’s strategy worked was that users ultimately felt it was worth paying for. Virality alone isn’t enough — if the product can’t convert attention into value, these approaches lose their edge. An app that can’t turn users into paying customers won’t benefit from the same playbook.

Third, we weren’t trying to build a forever company. That shaped a lot of the decisions we made. We didn’t invest heavily in long-term retention. We didn’t spend months optimizing infrastructure or customer support. This was about speed, testing, and leverage. If you’re aiming for product-market fit in a mission-driven, long-horizon startup, our shortcuts might not apply. Some of what made Glam Up successful — like front-loaded monetization, minimal backend complexity, and emotionally reactive pricing — doesn’t necessarily translate to companies optimizing for LTV or user trust over years.

Fourth, there are many things I didn’t cover. If I included every small test, weird insight, or backend decision, this paper would’ve been 1,000 pages long. So just know: there’s more. Things like App Store Optimization (ASO), strategies to “milk” content that already went viral, small UI tweaks that subtly boosted conversion. Those matter too. But I had to draw a line

somewhere. My goal here wasn't to document everything, but to distill what actually moved the needle. If you're building your own app, don't stop at this thesis. Keep digging.

Lastly, this paper is biased — by default. It's written by someone who was too close to the product, too emotionally involved, and too busy building to track every experiment perfectly. I tried to be honest, but hindsight always adds clarity that wasn't there in the moment. Some things worked because we planned them well. Others worked because we got lucky. I'm not always sure which was which.

12. Conclusion

Scaling a consumer app to 1 million users in six months wasn't the result of a genius idea, a viral hack, or some magical timing. It was the outcome of relentless testing, fast feedback loops, emotional intuition, and building systems that could scale once something clicked. Glam Up didn't start with a polished roadmap or product-market fit. It started with a phone call, a hunch, and a desperation to make something out of myself.

Looking back, what made Glam Up work wasn't any one feature or tactic—it was the combination of product decisions, marketing experiments, and viral design that all aligned around a single goal: grow fast by making something people want to share. Our referral system turned users into distribution channels. Our monetization play was emotional, not logical. Our content strategy wasn't polished, it was persistent. And our mindset? Delusional, obsessive, and uncomfortably fast.

But maybe the biggest lesson is this: building something that works doesn't mean it's something you want to keep building. Glam Up succeeded by all the external metrics: downloads, revenue, virality. But internally, I started craving chaos again. The mess of zero to

one. The curiosity of “will this even work?” So we pivoted. Not because Glam Up failed, but because it had already served its purpose. It was proof. And it became fuel.

Now, I think differently about product, growth, and what it takes to go viral. I don’t believe in perfect playbooks or waiting for the right moment. I believe in motion, systems, and staying close to what users actually feel. If you’ve made it this far in this thesis, I hope you walk away not with a list of tactics to copy, but a deeper understanding of how viral apps are built in real life—not in theory. And more than that, I hope it gives you the confidence to just start.

Because the truth is: nobody really knows what they’re doing. You just have to build anyway.

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